Healthy Eating and Physical Activity

Patient education sample document. For educational purposes only; not medical advice.

A healthy diet

A healthy diet protects against malnutrition and noncommunicable diseases such as diabetes, heart disease and stroke. The World Health Organization recommends eating at least 400 grams of fruits and vegetables per day. Free sugars should make up less than 10% of total energy intake, and total fat should be less than 30%. Salt intake should be less than 5 grams per day, which is about one teaspoon.

Building a balanced plate

- Fill half of your plate with vegetables and fruits.
- Choose whole grains such as brown rice, oats and whole wheat bread instead of refined grains.
- Include lean protein such as fish, beans, lentils, eggs and poultry.
- Choose unsaturated fats from olive oil, nuts and seeds, and limit saturated and trans fats.
- Drink water instead of sugary drinks.

Physical activity

Adults should do at least 150 to 300 minutes of moderate-intensity aerobic activity per week, or at least 75 to 150 minutes of vigorous activity. Muscle-strengthening activities should be done on two or more days each week. Moderate activity includes brisk walking, cycling and swimming. Regular activity lowers the risk of heart disease, type 2 diabetes, some cancers and depression.

Body mass index (BMI)

BMI is calculated as weight in kilograms divided by height in meters squared. A BMI below 18.5 is underweight, 18.5 to 24.9 is a healthy weight, 25 to 29.9 is overweight, and 30 or above is obesity. BMI is a screening tool and does not measure body fat directly, so it should be interpreted together with waist size and other health measures.

Sleep and hydration

Most adults need seven to nine hours of sleep per night. Poor sleep is linked to obesity, high blood pressure and weakened immunity. Drink enough fluids throughout the day; urine that is

pale yellow is a good sign of adequate hydration.

Healthy habits checklist

- Eat a variety of fresh, minimally processed foods.
- Limit salt, sugar and alcohol.
- Be active every day and avoid sitting for long periods.
- Do not smoke.
- See a healthcare professional for regular check-ups and screenings.